

OZVOR • PREMIUM GUIDE

The GEO Visibility Guide

How small businesses get cited by ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity & Gemini in 2026

Ozvor

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What you'll be able to do by the end of this guide: check, today, whether AI is naming your business or a competitor — and run the specific, research-backed moves that get you named, starting this week.

Do this first: the 10-minute check

Before anything else, find out where you actually stand. It costs nothing and takes ten minutes.

1. Open ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, and Google's AI Overview (or Gemini) in four tabs.
2. Ask each one the question your next customer would actually type — e.g. "best [your service] in [your city]" or "top [your category] for a small business."
3. For each engine, write down: were you named? Was a competitor named instead? Was anything said about you accurate?
4. Repeat with one more question — e.g. "[your service] vs. [main competitor]" or "how much does [your service] cost in [your city]."

If you weren't named on any of the eight checks, you're not alone — most small businesses aren't yet. The rest of this guide is the fix.

Prefer the automated version? The free **Ozvor AI Visibility Test** runs this exact check across all five engines, benchmarks you against three competitors, and scores you in about two minutes — no credit card. Start at ozvor.com/test.

In this guide

Why AI search changed the game · how engines decide who to cite · the five traits that get content cited · where AI actually looks · a 4-week posting plan · common mistakes · how to measure progress · a 90-day roadmap · the full Ozvor product ladder.

Why this matters now

For twenty years, ranking on Google meant customers would scroll and find you. That deal is closing. AI answer engines — ChatGPT, Google's AI Overviews, Gemini, Perplexity, Claude — now read the web for your customer and hand back a finished answer before a single link appears. And they don't return ten options. **They return two or three names.**

Signal	What the data shows	Source
Adoption	ChatGPT hit 900M weekly users (Feb 2026), up from 400M a year earlier	OpenAI, via TechCrunch
Adoption	Google AI Overviews reach 2B+ people/month	Alphabet Q2 2025 earnings
Behavior shift	37-44% of consumers/buyers now start research in an AI tool, not Google	Eight Oh Two 2025; Bain 2026
Click impact	AI summary present → only 8% click a regular link (vs. 15% with none); just 1% click inside the summary itself	Pew Research Center, Jul 2025
Click impact	68% of US Google searches now end with no click to the open web, up from ~60% in 2024	SparkToro / Rand Fishkin, Jun 2026
Local visibility	ChatGPT recommends only ~1.2% of local business locations when asked	SOCi 2026 Local Visibility Index

The trap: your Google ranking can hold steady while your clicks quietly disappear — because the AI answered the question and the searcher never scrolled down. One publisher held a stable #1 ranking while click-through fell from 5.1% to 0.6% (PPA). The scoreboard said "winning." The traffic was gone.

Why this hits small businesses hardest: big companies already have teams treating this as a priority. Most small businesses haven't heard the term "Generative Engine Optimization" (GEO). That gap is the opportunity — GEO is a measurable, research-backed discipline, not guesswork. A peer-reviewed Princeton/Georgia Tech/Allen Institute study proved you can lift a page's AI visibility by up to 40% with specific, repeatable edits (more in the next section). This is SEO circa 2010: high upside, low competition, and trust that compounds for whoever moves first.

How AI engines actually decide who to cite

There's a myth that a magic tag or file makes ChatGPT recommend you. It doesn't. **AI engines cite the clearest, most credible, most current answer to a question — and that comes from content, not code.**

Two doors, two speeds.

- **Training memory** (slow): what the model baked in when it was built. This is why Wikipedia and big publishers surface constantly. Anything you publish today won't reach this door until the next training run — months to a year away.
- **Live retrieval** (fast): the AI searches the web mid-answer and cites what it finds. A page you publish now can be cited within days or weeks. But ChatGPT only runs a live search on an estimated ~34.5% of queries (Siana Marketing, 2026, directional) — the rest answer from memory alone. You need both doors open.

Matching is by meaning, not keywords. "We're passionate about beautiful smiles" matches nothing — no customer types that. "Invisalign in Austin runs \$3,500-\$6,000 and takes 12-18 months" matches a real question with a number, place, and timeframe.

Engine	How it retrieves	What it means for you
ChatGPT	Live search on ~1 in 3 queries; heavy on Bing, Wikipedia, Reddit	Be indexed on Bing and answer-ready; don't rely on it always searching
Perplexity	Retrieval-first — nearly every answer is a live search	Your fastest feedback loop; fresh, accessible pages surface soonest
Claude	Searches live only when the question needs current info	Reputation and sourcing across the wider web matter most
Gemini / Google AIO	Tied to Google's live index; most reliable engine for reading schema	Classic SEO crawlability still carries real weight

Skip the "magic markup." In a synthesis of 54 experiments, structured data (schema) scored just 5.6 out of 10 on citation impact — well below content and crawlability (Cyrus Shepard / Zyppy, 2026). `llms.txt` scored 2.0, near the bottom, with no credible evidence it earns citations (same source). Schema is fine basic hygiene; it is not the lever. If a vendor's pitch is "add our tag and ChatGPT will recommend you," that's not what the evidence shows.

Winning on one engine doesn't mean winning on the next: only 45% of the top-20 traditional local-search brands also appear in the top-20 AI recommendations (SOCi 2026). That's why checking across all five engines — not guessing at one — matters.

The 5 traits that get content cited

In 2024, researchers from Princeton, Georgia Tech, the Allen Institute for AI, and IIT Delhi ran a controlled experiment — 10,000 real queries across 25 domains — testing nine ways of editing content to see what actually earned citations. [Aggarwal et al., *GEO: Generative Engine Optimization*, KDD 2024, arXiv:2311.09735] The result: the right edits lifted a page's AI visibility by up to 40%. The moves that worked are the hallmarks of genuinely credible writing — not tricks.

#	Trait	Visibility lift	Do this
1	Quotations from credible sources	+41% (strongest single tactic)	Find one quotable line from an expert, regulator, or study and build a short post around it, sourced by name.
2	Statistics — concrete numbers	+33%	Pull a real number from your own work ("across our last 20 jobs, average X") and use it, labeled honestly as your own data.
3	Citing sources inline	+28% avg, up to +115% for an underdog page ranked 5th	Add two or three named, checkable citations to your best existing post.
4	Specificity — answer one narrow question exactly	Matches the way AI retrieval works (meaning-matching)	Write down the three most specific questions customers ask on a first call. Answer just one, completely.
5	Single-idea focus + a clear stance , published on a steady cadence	Hedged, everything-at-once posts get cited for nothing	Pick two fixed publishing days a week. One idea per post, with a number or source in every one.

The one thing that backfires: keyword stuffing — the old SEO reflex — cut visibility by **-8.7%**, the only tactic in the study that hurt. AI engines parse meaning, not keyword density.

Underdog example (financial advisor). BAD: "Index funds are usually a smart choice for long-term investors." GOOD: "Per S&P Dow Jones Indices' SPIVA scorecard, ~88% of large-cap U.S. fund managers underperformed the S&P 500 over the 15 years ending 2023 — that's the case for low-cost index funds in one sentence." The second version anchors the claim to a named, checkable source, and per the research, a page like this starting at position 5 can more than double its visibility.

You don't need a big following to benefit from any of this — Semrush found the *median* AI-cited LinkedIn post had just 15-25 reactions (Jan-Feb 2026). The model isn't counting your likes. It's reading your answer.

Where AI actually looks

A handful of domains account for most AI citations — which tells you where an hour of effort buys the most visibility.

Rank	Source	Share of citations	Note
1	Reddit	~3.1% of all citations; #1 on Perplexity	Post there today, for free (Profound, 4B+ citations)
2	LinkedIn	~11% avg citation rate, up to 14.3% on ChatGPT Search	Original posts, not follower count, drive this (Semrush)
3	Wikipedia	16.3% of ChatGPT's citations	Largely out of reach for a business page
4	YouTube	~2.1% overall	Reviews and demos
—	Quora	4th most-cited in Google's AI Mode (~7.25%)	Long, complete answers (535+ words) win here

The honest catch: Ahrefs found 67.7% of ChatGPT's top 1,000 citations are effectively off-limits to marketers — Wikipedia, brand homepages, app stores. **Only ~32.3% of citation "seats" are genuinely contestable:** educational pages, review sites, news, and blogs (Ahrefs, Sep 2025). That's clarifying, not discouraging — it tells you exactly where to spend effort.

Your fastest, most controllable win: reviews. Vendor research indicates brands on 2+ review platforms are roughly 3.4x more likely to be mentioned by ChatGPT (G2 / SE Ranking roundup, directional). For local businesses, SOCi found AI-recommended businesses averaged 4.3 stars. Get listed and reviewed on at least two relevant platforms this week.

Your business	Lead with	Then
Local services (HVAC, plumbing, dental, restaurants)	Google Business Profile + reviews	Reddit (city/niche subreddits)
B2B software / SaaS	G2 + Capterra reviews	LinkedIn posts answering buyer questions
Professional services (law, accounting, consulting)	LinkedIn original posts	Quora answers in your specialty
Local retail / food	Google Business Profile, flawless and complete	Steady review requests

One more truth: where AI pulls from **shifts monthly** — Reddit's share of ChatGPT citations swung from ~60% to ~10% in six weeks in 2025 (Semrush). That volatility is the argument for ongoing monitoring, not a one-time audit.

Your 4-week posting plan

Eight posts, two a week, fifteen minutes of research before each one. Built on the Princeton findings above and on Semrush's analysis of which LinkedIn posts AI engines actually cite.

Before every post (15 minutes): collect one of — a statistic with a named source and date, a quotable line you can attribute, or a specific observation from your own work this week ("across our last 20 installs, the average...").

Never publish a post with none of the three.

Week	Monday	Thursday
1	The Data Story — one number, the source, what it means for your customer (150-250 words)	The How-We-Did-It Case — situation → what you did → result, one real number (150-250 words)
2	The Contrarian Take — one piece of common advice that's wrong for your customer, and why (200-300 words)	The Full FAQ Answer — your most-asked question, answered completely, no teaser (200-300 words)
3	The Single-Niche Post — speak to one specific customer type, not "everyone" (150-250 words)	The Mistake Confession — a real mistake and the correct approach (150-250 words)
4	The Definition Frame — define one loosely-used industry term precisely for your customer (150-250 words)	The Review — one concrete thing you observed this month; set up week 5 (100-200 words)

Distribution order: LinkedIn first, always (its ~11% average citation rate makes it the highest-probability surface) → Facebook as written → Instagram as a caption extract → your own site/blog last, for the compounding, freshness-favored copy.

Pre-publish checklist — every post, every time:

- [] One specific anchor: a number, a named source, or a real described situation
 - [] Answers one question completely, not seven half-answers
 - [] Phrased the way a customer would actually ask
 - [] A clear, quotable takeaway
 - [] Under 20% "book/buy/call us" — AI cites answers, not pitches
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Local & industry specifics

For "near me" businesses, the shift is starkest: ChatGPT recommends only ~1.2% of locations, versus 35.9% that appear in Google's local 3-pack (SOCi 2026). Winning old local SEO doesn't carry over — only 45% of top-20 traditional local brands also rank top-20 in AI. And AI is quietly wrong more often than you'd expect: business-profile details were only ~68% accurate on ChatGPT and Perplexity (SOCi 2026) — your hours, address, and services, described with a 1-in-3 chance of being off.

Three levers that move local AI visibility:

1. **Reviews, in volume and recency.** Vendor research suggests 50+ recent reviews correlate with ~3x higher odds of AI recommendation (GrowthPro, directional). Build a same-day text-with-link habit rather than a one-time push.
2. **An accurate Google Business Profile.** Fill every field — services, service areas, hours, plain-language descriptions ("emergency water heater repair," not "residential thermal solutions"). Gemini scored 100% profile accuracy pulling straight from it (SOCi 2026).
3. **Recency everywhere.** AI-cited pages run ~25.7% fresher than top-10 organic results (Ahrefs, ~17M citations, Dec 2025). A regularly updated FAQ or service page beats a static one.

One honest caveat: conversion-lift claims vary by study. Amsive's 54-site study found AI and organic conversion statistically indistinguishable overall (4.87% vs. 4.60%, $p=0.794$), even as some other studies report higher lifts. We'd rather you see the range than a cherry-picked number.

Six mistakes that quietly cost you citations

Mistake	Why it fails	Fix
Over-promotion	The Princeton study found keyword-stuffed, sales-first content is the <i>only</i> tactic that reduced visibility (-8.7%)	Keep pitches under 20% of any post
Jargon without explanation	Retrieval matches customers' actual words, not industry terms	Write "why is my AC freezing up," not "evaporator coil ice formation"
Daily-posting fatigue	Volume without quality doesn't help — the median cited post had 15-25 reactions, not virality	Two sharp posts a week beats fourteen rushed ones
Engagement bait ("drop a 🔥")	Built for platform reach, invisible to AI retrieval	Write to answer the question, not farm comments
Inconsistency	Freshness is a relevance signal that compounds; gaps forfeit your seat to a competitor	Hold the two-day-a-week cadence, every week
Keyword stuffing	Measured at -8.7% visibility — the only tactic that backfired	Say the thing once, clearly, in context

How to measure what's working

There's no official API that reports when an AI names your business — measurement is hands-on, and entirely doable.

- 1 . Pick 8-10 real-prospect queries ("best [service] in [city]," "[service] vs [alternative]," "how much does [service] cost").
- 2 . Run each one weekly across all four engines.
- 3 . Log: were you named? Quoted or paraphrased? What source did the engine link? Was the description accurate?
- 4 . Track it in a simple spreadsheet, or let Ozvor automate the sweep and roll it into one score.

Timeframe	What to expect
Weeks 1-3	No citations yet — normal, not failure. You're building the base.
~Week 4	First movement on narrow, specific queries
Weeks 4-8	Citations accumulate; descriptions start firming up
3+ months	Broader, higher-competition queries begin to move

Reading your results: named and accurate → keep the cadence, expand to adjacent queries. Named but wrong → strengthen your owned profiles so the engine has accurate material to pull from. Not named after 8 weeks of consistent posting → your content likely still doesn't match how customers phrase questions, or you're in a low-volume niche.

Why it's worth the effort: Seer Interactive found brands cited inside a Google AI Overview earn ~120% more clicks on the same query, and Microsoft Clarity found AI-referred visitors sign up at markedly higher rates than search visitors — though, again, Amsive's 54-site study found no significant conversion difference overall. The direction is consistently positive; treat the exact multiplier as directional.

Your 90-day roadmap

Phase	Days	Focus	Milestone
1 — See the truth	1-30	Run your audit across all engines. Map the 5 brands AI names repeatedly. Fix crawlability. Claim 2+ review platforms.	A written baseline: your score, your competitors, your gaps
2 — Build credibility	31-60	Publish 4-6 pieces using the 5 traits above (quotes, stats, citations, specificity, cadence)	Genuinely useful, well-sourced content live on your channels
3 — Monitor and compound	61-90	Re-run the audit. Double down on what earned citations; refresh what didn't. Keep publishing.	A repeatable monthly rhythm, and your first citations appearing

Only ~16% of brands systematically track their AI search performance (HubSpot, 2025) — most of your competitors have no idea where they stand. That's your opening.

What GEO can do: make you visible and citable in AI answers, put you on the shortlist when a customer asks, and send better-qualified visitors your way. **What it can't do:** guarantee a #1 spot, work overnight, or replace doing genuinely good work. Anyone promising guaranteed rankings is selling something the science doesn't support.

The Ozvor path, step by step

Everything above is doable by hand. The catch is that it never stops — the audit needs re-running, citation sources shift monthly, and content has to keep coming. Ozvor automates the parts that quietly get dropped when you're busy running the business.

Step	Product	Price	Best for
1	Free AI Visibility Test (ozvor.com/test)	\$0, no card	See where you stand today across all five engines
2	The Get-Cited Kit	\$29 one-time	The templates, checklists, and prompts in this guide, ready to use — no subscription
3	Growth (ozvor.com/pricing)	\$99/mo	Weekly monitoring, citation tracking, and GEO content for 1 brand
3	Agency (ozvor.com/agencies)	\$249/mo	The same engine across up to 25 brands, with white-label reports
4	OrganicPosts by Ozvor (ozvor.com/organicposts)	done-for-you	We draft and schedule the citation-shaped posts; you approve every one before it goes live

Every plan runs on the same rule as this guide: we measure what's actually happening across ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, Gemini, and Google AI Overview — we never fabricate a score or a citation that isn't there.

Start now

You don't need a platform to begin — the 10-minute check on page one and the 4-week plan above work by hand. But the checking, the monitoring, and the content don't stop after month one, and that's exactly what gets dropped when things get busy.

Run your free AI Visibility Test today at ozvor.com/test. See where you actually stand — then decide how much of the rest you want to automate.

Sources

The core research

- Aggarwal et al., *GEO: Generative Engine Optimization* (Princeton / Georgia Tech / Allen Institute for AI / IIT Delhi), KDD 2024 — [arXiv:2311.09735](https://arxiv.org/abs/2311.09735) · <https://arxiv.org/abs/2311.09735>
- Cyrus Shepard / Zyppy — AI citation ranking factors, synthesis of 54 experiments — <https://signal.zyppy.com/p/ai-citation-ranking-factors>
- Otterly.ai — schema markup's real impact on AI search — <https://otterly.ai/blog/schema-markup-real-impact-ai-search/>

Scale of the shift

- OpenAI / ChatGPT 900M weekly users, via TechCrunch — <https://techcrunch.com/2026/02/27/chatgpt-reaches-900m-weekly-active-users/>
- Google AI Overviews, 2B monthly users, via TechCrunch — <https://techcrunch.com/2025/07/23/googles-ai-overviews-have-2b-monthly-users-ai-mode-100m-in-the-us-and-india/>
- Pew Research Center — AI summaries and link clicks, Jul 2025 — <https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2025/07/22/google-users-are-less-likely-to-click-on-links-when-an-ai-summary-appears-in-the-results/>
- SparkToro / Rand Fishkin — 2026 zero-click study — <https://sparktoro.com/blog/in-2026-less-than-one-third-of-google-searches-still-send-a-click/>

Where AI cites from

- Profound — Reddit & AI search, 4B+ citations — <https://www.tryprofound.com/blog/the-data-on-reddit-and-ai-search>
- Semrush — LinkedIn AI Visibility Study — <https://www.semrush.com/blog/linkedin-ai-visibility-study/>
- Ahrefs — ChatGPT's most-cited pages (67% off-limits) — <https://ahrefs.com/blog/chatgpts-most-cited-pages/>
- Ahrefs — fresh content and AI citations — <https://ahrefs.com/blog/fresh-content/>
- SE Ranking — review platforms in AI Overviews — <https://seranking.com/blog/review-platforms-in-ai-overviews/>

SMB & local

- SOCi 2026 Local Visibility Index, via Search Engine Land — <https://searchengineland.com/ai-local-visibility-report-2026-468085>
- BrightLocal — Local Consumer Review Survey 2026 — <https://www.brightlocal.com/research/lcrs-ai-trust/>
- 5WPR HVAC & Plumbing AI Visibility Index, via Plumbing & Mechanical — <https://www.pmmag.com/articles/107415-87-of-hvac-and-plumbing-contractors-are-invisible-when-home-owners-ask-ai>

Funnel & conversion (including the honest counter-evidence)

- Seer Interactive — AI Overview impact on CTR, 2026 — <https://www.seerinteractive.com/insights/aio-impact-on-google-ctr-2026-update>
- Microsoft Clarity — AI traffic conversion study — <https://clarity.microsoft.com/blog/ai-traffic-converts-at-3x-the-rate-of-other-channels-study/>

- Amsive — does LLM traffic convert better than organic? 54-site study — <https://www.amsive.com/insights/seo/does-llm-traffic-convert-better-than-organic-a-new-data-backed-study/>
 - HubSpot — Generative Engine Optimization for small business — <https://blog.hubspot.com/marketing/generative-engine-optimization-small-business>
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About Ozvor

Ozvor audits how your brand appears across ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, Gemini, and Google AI Overview, computes your **Ozvor AI Visibility Score** on three weighted vectors (Brand 30% / Performance 35% / AI 35%), benchmarks you against real competitors, and builds the GEO content plan around the levers in this guide. **OrganicPosts by Ozvor** is the done-for-you arm — content drafted and scheduled for you, AI involvement disclosed on every draft, your approval required before anything goes live.

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